



STRATEGIC SHIFT

TDP leader Chandrababu Naidu comes out in favour of carving out a new state from within Andhra Pradesh. But the switch may not help his weakened party in the coming electoral battle.

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

It was on Dussehra that Telugu Desam Party (TDP) supremo N. Chandrababu Naidu bit the Telangana bullet. Having dodged the issue for over two years, Naidu endorsed the demand for a separate state on the day Telugu megastar Chiranjeevi began his maiden political tour of the state under the Praja Rajyam Party (PRP) banner.

"TDP has credibility and people know we stick to whatever we say. The party's core group had recommended statehood on the basis of the sentiments of the Telangana people," the TDP chief says bravely. Naidu's real compulsion for the biggest-ever reversal of stance in the 26-year-old party's history is the apprehension of losing support in Telangana, where the party fared poorly in the 2004 elections, the increasing influence of the PRP in the coastal districts and his poor prospects in the Rayalaseema region which is

under the sway of Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy. Naidu's switch means he's trying to trade the TDP's declining support in the state's coastal districts for fresh support in Telangana.

In the last Assembly elections, the TDP suffered major reverses in Telangana where the Congress and its electoral ally, the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS), bagged 80 of the 107 seats. With the recent redrawing of constituency contours, there are 119 Assembly seats in Telangana, while those in coastal Andhra come down from 134 to 123 and down from 53 to 52 in Rayalaseema. The total remains at 294. There are 16 Lok Sabha constituencies in Telangana now; Andhra Pradesh may be the only state that votes for an Assembly along with the Lok Sabha elections. Any party that strikes it rich in Telangana may well be vital in forming the next government at the Centre.

With the TDP, CPI, CPI(M) and TRS trying to forge an electoral alliance in Andhra Pradesh, the TDP